
FIRST PASS

CANADA / TECHNICAL ROLES

The Screen Report

What 141 Canadian technical job postings ask before a person reads your resume.

Free sample. The paid pack is 21 pages.

Data collected 5 October 2026. Every count in this document is measured from the 141 postings named in the method note. Nothing here is estimated.

<https://maxhemmerich.github.io/first-pass-ca/>

Method

Between 24 September and 5 October 2026, 141 Canadian job postings for technical roles were collected: data analyst, business intelligence, data engineering, machine learning, clinical data and software roles, almost all of them in Ontario. 140 were readable in full.

43 of those postings published the employer's own application questions together with the form fields, so those 43 could be counted instead of guessed at. 39 published the answer set that went with them. 53 were scored against a written fit rubric. Across the 43, there are 224 distinct question strings.

What this is not

- It is not a random sample of the Canadian market and it is not a survey of employers. It is one applicant's pipeline, counted.
- It is not a description of how any named company's screening software works internally. Nothing here comes from inside a vendor's system.
- It asserts nothing about hiring outcomes. No placement result is claimed anywhere in this document.

How to read a number in this report

Every count is a match against those posting texts. Excel 56 means 56 of the 140 readable postings contain the word Excel. salary 27 / 43 means 27 of the 43 postings that published questions ask something about pay. Where a claim about the screening process appears, it is written as what the posting itself exposes: a required field, a knockout question, a character limit, a published band.

Announcements about artificial intelligence in hiring describe software nobody outside the vendor can inspect. What you can inspect is the form you are being asked to fill in. That form is where the decision starts, and it is the only part of the process you can read before you are rejected.

The questions employers actually ask

Counted from the 43 postings that published their own screening questions. The bar shows the share of those 43.

Salary expectations asked in 25 different wordings	27	
Work authorization or visa sponsorship wording varies: eligible, authorized, require sponsorship	12	
Years of experience often a required field on every row of a skills grid	10	
A completed degree bachelor, master, or post-secondary	6	
Technologies, by name one caps the answer at 200 characters	6	
Location or commuting distance Greater Toronto Area or reasonable commute	5	
References or a background check consent wording included with the application	4	
Accommodation requests an offer to state needs, optional	3	
French proficiency a five-level scale, not a yes or no	2	
Start date or availability notice period	1	

The two extremes in one sample

One posting asks you to fill a grid of 41 skills, and every single row carries its own required Years of experience* and Proficiency* value. Another posting asks what technologies you know and stops you at 200 characters. One wants structured volume, the other wants editing. Answering both the same way loses one of them.

A required field with an asterisk is the first screen, and it is not scored on quality. If it is blank, the form does not submit. If it contradicts a hard requirement in the posting, no amount of resume quality reverses it.

The same question, 25 wordings

Verbatim from the postings that ask about pay, punctuation as published. The count on the left is how many postings used that exact wording.

- 3 Please indicate your minimum annual salary expectations (Non-Union positions only):
- 3 What are your salary expectations?
- 2 What is your desired pay rate?
- 2 What are your base salary expectations?
- 2 What is your expected salary?
- 1 What is your desired salary?
- 1 What is your desired annual salary?
- 1 what is your desired annual base salary?
- 1 What are your salary expectations for this position?
- 1 What are your salary expectations for the position?
- 1 What are your annual salary expectations for this position?
- 1 What are your annual salary expectations in CAD?
- 1 What are your annual salary expectations in USD?
- 1 What is your target salary expectation (specific figure or range) for this position?
- 1 Please give your desired total annual compensation
- 1 What are your salary expectations for this entry level, hybrid full-time role? Please ensure you mention your response to be considered further.
- 1 What are your salary expectations for this entry-level, hybrid full-time role? Please refer to the salary range listed in the job posting when providing your response.
- 1 What is your desired salary for this position? (You may include a single number or a range.) USD.
- 1 The poster outlines our salary band at the job grade 13 level (\$66,179 - 77,858) along with more details on a potential performance bonus (3-5%)
- 1 This position offers an annual base salary of \$95k-\$105k + an additional 12% annual bonus. Does this align with your expectations?

Read those three at the bottom again. One tells you the band and the bonus before you answer. One tells you to read the band on the posting before you answer. One asks whether a specific number works for you, which is a yes-or-no, not a negotiation. Those three are answered differently, and none of them is answered with the word competitive.

27 of 43 postings ask about money. The answer you type into the form is the number you are later anchored to. That is the whole reason the paid pack puts the salary section before the interview section.

What the posting tells you before a human reads anything

1. **The asterisk.** Required fields are the first screen. In this sample they are the pay box, the years-of-experience box and the skills grid.
2. **The knockout questions.** Work authorization and sponsorship (12 of 43), a completed degree (6 of 43), and location or commute (5 of 43). These are single-select, and a wrong answer is not a judgement call, it is a filter.
3. **The character limit.** A published cap of 200 characters for a technologies answer. A cap is a test of editing, not of knowledge.
4. **The skills grid.** A row per skill, with required years and proficiency. One posting in the sample has 41 rows.
5. **The consent box.** Background checks and reference release appear in 4 of 43 postings, with release wording you accept before you can submit.
6. **The published band.** Seven salary bands and two hourly rates in this sample. Where one exists, it is the number to anchor to.

The published bands in this sample

Band as published	Kind
\$45,000 – \$55,000	annual
\$50,000 – \$60,000	annual
\$63,700 – \$74,900	annual
\$65,000 – \$75,000	annual
\$75,000 – \$85,000	annual
\$86,379 – \$127,288	annual
\$110,000 – \$130,000	annual
\$37.47 – \$46.84	hourly
\$40.49 – \$60.73	hourly

Quoted from postings that chose to publish a band, so these are examples from this sample, not a market range.

One employer published its grade structure with the range: job grade 13 level, \$66,179 to 77,858, plus a 3-5% performance bonus.

How to answer inside 200 characters

The cap in this sample reads: What technologies are you proficient in? Answer size should be 200 characters or less. Two hundred characters is about 30 words. You cannot list fifteen tools and you should not try.

The order that survives a 30-word limit

1. The one tool the posting names first.
2. The level, in the posting's own vocabulary (proficient, advanced, expert), not in yours.
3. Where you used it, as a workplace type rather than a company story.
4. One line of proof: how many, how often, for whom.

A template, with the parts you replace

Power BI (5 years, report author), SQL (advanced, ETL and tuning),
Python 3 (pandas, reporting automation), Excel (expert, Power Query).
Built and maintained 20+ recurring reports for operations teams.

That is 179 characters. The years and counts are placeholders: put your own measured numbers in, and never write a range you have not worked.

What loses characters for nothing

- Adjectives: passionate, detail-oriented, results-driven. A parser does not score them. A human reads them as noise in a box that was already tight.
- A tool the posting never mentions, taking the slot of one it does.
- Spelling the tool differently from the posting. Use the posting's spelling, character for character, in both the form and the resume.
- "Familiar with" in front of something you have used for years.

The anchor rule

If the posting publishes a band, that band is the target and the ceiling. Answer inside it, above the midpoint, with a reason that points at the posting's own requirements. If the posting publishes nothing, give a range with a floor you would actually accept, because the form usually allows one answer and keeps it.

Four lines that do the work. Replace the bracketed parts.

Band published, form asks for one number:

"I am targeting \$[number], which sits in the upper half of your posted range of \$[band low] to \$[band high], based on [the requirement from the posting that you meet]."

Band published, but the number is demanded with no explanation box:

"\$[number], within your posted range."

No band published:

"For this scope my range is \$[low] to \$[high]. Where does the posted band land?"

The band is below your floor:

"The scope here looks closer to [what the role does], and my range starts at \$[floor]. If the band is firm, I understand. What flexibility is there on title, bonus, or review date?"

Three bands from this sample, used as anchors

- \$75,000 – \$85,000: an analytics role. Midpoint \$80,000. Anchor at \$82,000 to \$84,000.
- \$86,379 – \$127,288: a wide band, which usually means a level is being placed inside it. Anchor to the level you can evidence, not to the top of the range.
- \$110,000 – \$130,000: a senior data role. Anchor at \$120,000 with the requirement you meet named in the same sentence.

Never answer a published band with "negotiable" or "open to discussion". The employer has published a number and asked you to place yourself beside it. Declining to place yourself moves you to the bottom of the band in every reading of that exchange.

What the paid pack adds

The Screen Report is the measured result. The pack, **First Pass**, is 21 pages of what to do with it: the answer shape for every question in the ranked list, the keyword map by role family, the salary scripts in full, twelve screening-call questions with model answers, the negotiation section written for the Canadian market, and the reference tables.

Section	What it gives you	Pages
01 How the screen works	The observable signals, and what is not observable	3-4
02 The decision questions	Each question, what it tests, the answer shape, the failure mode	5-6
03 Work authorization	The real wordings, and what a Canadian applicant answers	7-8
04 Keyword map	By role family, with where each term belongs on the page	9-11
05 The salary question	25 wordings, the anchor rule, three complete scripts	12-14
06 The screening call	12 questions by level, with the answer shape	15-16
07 Negotiation, Canada	Bands, counters, bonus components, when to stop	17-18
08 Reference	Full keyword table, question list, one-page checklist	19-21

Where to get it

The pack is \$24 CAD and the page is <https://maxhemmerich.github.io/first-pass-ca/>. Payment is not connected yet: nothing has been sold. The free report you are reading is the one that is live and downloadable, and corrections to its data are welcome.

Limits, once more, on the last page where you can still read them

- 141 postings, Ontario-heavy, collected on 5 October 2026. Not a market survey.
- This document is information, not advice, not legal or immigration or tax advice, and not a promise of an interview or a job.
- No employer endorsed this document or supplied anything in it.